16 July 1960, the Soviet government scrapped 600 contracts it had signed with China and informed the government in Beijing of its decision to withdraw all its 1,390 experts in China between 28 July and 1 September.[46] But that did not deter the leadership in Beijing from going ahead with their nuclear programme, now entirely staffed with Chinese technicians and paid for with allocations from the state's military budget. On 16 October 1964, China conducted its first nuclear test. A second test was carried out on 14 May 1965, followed by a third on 9 May 1966. China had now established itself as a nuclear power.

Regarding Mao's own attitude to nuclear weapons, it was long speculated whether he had really said in his famous 'US imperialism is a paper tiger' speech before a meeting with the world's Communist parties in Moscow in November 1957 that, 'I'm not afraid of nuclear war. There are 2.7 billion people in the world; it doesn't matter if some are killed. China has a population of 600 million; even if half of them are killed, there are still 300 million people left. I'm not afraid of anyone.'[47] But in March 2013, the Chinese government's documentary TV channel, CCTV-9, ran an 18-part series on declassified Sino-Russian foreign affairs files dating back to the time Mao was in power. One episode showed him saying exactly that.[48]

Until then, many people—especially Chinese—had refused to believe that the leader of China could have been that callous. But the Chairman himself had actually refused to deny it when Edgar Snow, the American author of the famous book *Red Star Over China*, asked him about it in an 1965 interview. 'Mao would not deny anything he had said, nor did he wish me to deny for him the so-called rumour' (about China's millions' power of survival in a nuclear war).[49]

In the same month as the third nuclear test was conducted, May 1966, Mao decided the time was ripe to launch his Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution to purge the Party and the State of all 'counterrevolutionaries, revisionists and capitalist roaders'.[50] Already in December 1965, General Luo Ruiqing, a PLA veteran and its joint chief of staff, had been dismissed from his post for his reluctance to follow Mao's idea of emphasizing ideological training within the army, a line ardently followed by Mao and Defence Minister Lin Biao. Luo was lumped together with the CCP chief of Beijing, Peng Zhen, Propaganda Department Director Lu Dingyi, and